

Hindi, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/hindi/lessons/

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Devanagari set in Noto Sans Devanagari (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This is the Hindi volume of the same project as the Spanish, French, German, and Arabic ones. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Devanagari letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read नमस्ते *and* learn that it means “I bow to you” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already knows Devanagari simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Hindi’s depth comes from a double inheritance. Much of its core vocabulary is **Sanskrit** — नमस्ते and धन्यवाद sit on ancient roots (*nam*, “to bow”; *dhanya*, “worthy”). But centuries of Persian as the language of courts layered on a second vocabulary, Persian and (through it) Arabic — so “thanks” is also शुक्रिया (*shukriyā*, the same Semitic root as Arabic *shukran*), and “farewell” is अलविदा (*alvidā*, “the farewell,” carrying the Arabic article *al-*). The book keeps both streams in view.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest honest web of connections; the cultural reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

Contents

Preface	iii
Devanagari (reference)	1
1 Greetings	3
1.1 नमस्ते (<i>namaste</i>) — “I bow to you”	3
1.2 नमस्कार (<i>namaskār</i>) — the more formal bow	4
1.3 धन्यवाद (<i>dhanyavād</i>) — “thank you,” the Sanskrit way	4
1.4 शुक्रिया (<i>shukriyā</i>) — Hindi’s other heritage	5
1.5 अलविदा (<i>alvidā</i>) — “the farewell”	5
2 Introducing Yourself	7
2.1 नाम (<i>nām</i>) — “name,” a word older than Europe	7
2.2 मेरा (<i>merā</i>) — “my”	8
2.3 है (<i>hai</i>) — “is,” cousin of English <i>is</i>	8
2.4 मेरा नाम ...है (<i>merā nām ...hai</i>) — “my name is...”	8
2.5 आप / तुम (<i>āp / tum</i>) — “you,” respectful and familiar	9
2.6 क्या (<i>kyā</i>) — “what”	9
2.7 आपका नाम क्या है? (<i>āpkā nām kyā hai</i>) — “what’s your name?”	10
2.8 खुशी (<i>khushī</i>) — “happiness,” and “pleased to meet you” . . .	10
2.9 The whole exchange	10
3 How Are You?	13
3.1 कैसे (<i>kaise</i>) — “how,” another of the k- questions	13
3.2 आप कैसे हैं? (<i>āp kaise haiṃ</i>) — “how are you?”	14
3.3 मैं (<i>maiṃ</i>) — “I,” the m- of the first person	14
3.4 हूँ (<i>hūṃ</i>) — “am,” cousin of English <i>am</i>	14
3.5 ठीक (<i>thīk</i>) — “fine,” and how to answer	15
3.6 आपका स्वागत है (<i>āpkā svāgat hai</i>) — “you’re welcome”	15
3.7 The whole exchange	16

4	Farewells	17
4.1	फिर (<i>phir</i>) — “again”	17
4.2	मिलेंगे (<i>milenge</i>) — “(we) will meet”	17
4.3	फिर मिलेंगे (<i>phir milenge</i>) — “we’ll meet again”	18
4.4	कल मिलते हैं (<i>kal milte haiṃ</i>) — “see you tomorrow”	18
4.5	चलता हूँ (<i>caltā hūṃ</i>) — “I’ll be off”	19
4.6	The farewells	19
5	The First Verbs	21
5.1	बोलना (<i>bolnā</i>) — “to speak,” your first full verb	21
5.2	मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ (<i>maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ</i>) — “I speak Hindi” . . .	22
5.3	रहना (<i>rahnā</i>) — “to live, to stay”	22
5.4	करना (<i>karnā</i>) — “to do,” the most useful verb in Hindi	23
5.5	Sentences about yourself	23

Devanagari — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a”**: क = ka, न = na, म = ma.
2. **A vowel sign (*mātrā*) changes that vowel**: ा = ā (का kā), ि = i (written before, read after), े = e (के ke), and ि ु ू ै ो ौ for ī, u, ū, ai, o, au.
3. **A *halant* (ँ) removes the built-in vowel**: क् = bare k. A vowel-less consonant leans onto the next as a **conjunct**: स् + त → स्त (st), न् + य → न्य (ny).

Independent vowels (word-initial)

अ a · आ ā · इ i · ई ī · उ u · ऊ ū · ए e · ऐ ai · ओ o · औ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration** distinguishes letters: क k / ख kh, त t / थ th, द d / ध dh — the “h” is a real puff.
- **Retroflex** (ट ड ण) vs. **dental** (त द न): tongue curled back vs. on the teeth.
- **Nukta** (a dot below) marks Perso-Arabic/English sounds: ज़ z, फ़ f, क़ q.

The two vocabularies

Many everyday ideas have two Hindi words — a **Sanskrit** one, often formal (*dhanyavād*, *namaste*), and a **Perso-Arabic** one, often everyday (*shukriyā*, *alvidā*). The lessons trace which is which.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Hindi greetings — and, taught through them, how to read Devanagari and Hindi’s double inheritance (Sanskrit and Perso-Arabic). Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C01-*.md.*

1.1 नमस्ते (*namaste*) — “I bow to you”

The letters in this word

Hindi reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न na, म ma, स sa, त ta. A vowel sign changes the vowel: े makes “e” (ते = te). A *halant* (the stroke under स्) *removes* the vowel, and the bare consonant leans onto the next as a **conjunct**: स् + ते → स्ते. Read left to right: न·म·स्ते → *namaste*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्ते = नमः (*namah*, “a bow, reverence,” from Sanskrit root नम् *nam*, “to bow”) + ते (*te*, “to you”) = literally “**I bow to you**.” The root *nam* also builds *namaskār* (next), and *namaste* is borrowed whole into English.

Why it’s said this way

A real gesture, not a bland “hi”: said with palms pressed together, in respect. Works as both hello and goodbye, any time, polite without being stiff.

1.2 नमस्कार (*namaskār*) — the more formal bow

The letters in this word

New: क ka, र ra, and the sign ा for long “ā” (का = kā). You already read नमस् (*namas*). न·म·स्·का·र → *namaskār*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कार = नमः (*namah*, “bow,” root *nam*) + कार (*kāra*, “the making/doing of,” from Sanskrit कृ *kr*, “to do”). Literally “the making of a bow.” That piece *-kāra* (“the act of _____”) recurs across Sanskrit vocabulary.

A notch more **formal** than *namaste* — ceremonial, or for elders and writing.

1.3 धन्यवाद (*dhanyavād*) — “thank you,” the Sanskrit way

The letters in this word

New: ध dha, य ya, व va, द da, and a new conjunct न् + य → न्य (“*nya*”). ध·न्·य·वा·द → *dhanyavād*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवाद = धन्य (*dhanya*, “worthy, blessed,” from धन *dhana*, “wealth”) + वाद (*vāda*, “a saying,” from Sanskrit वद् *vad*, “to speak”). Literally “an utterance of [you are] worthy” — a formal, literary “thanks.”

Why it’s said this way

The **formal, Sanskritic** “thank you” — written, official, respectful. For everyday thanks Hindi often reaches for a lighter Persian word, शुक्रिया — next — and holding the two together is the best window into Hindi.

1.4 शुक्रिया (*shukriyā*) — Hindi's other heritage

The letters in this word

New: श sha, and the sign ि for “i” (written *before* the consonant, read *after*). With a conjunct क् + र → क्र (“kra”): शु·क्·रि·या → *shukriyā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

शुक्रिया is *not* Sanskrit. It came through Persian from **Arabic** *shukr* (“gratitude”), root **sh-k-r** — the *same word* as Arabic *shukran*. Two unrelated languages, one Semitic root for thanks.

Why it's said this way

Centuries of Persian as the court language poured Persian and Arabic words into everyday Hindi/Urdu, so Hindi carries **two vocabularies**: Sanskrit (*dhanyavād*, *namaste*) and Perso-Arabic (*shukriyā*, *alvidā*). Often the Sanskrit word is formal and the Persian one everyday. *shukriyā* is the casual, everyday “thanks.”

1.5 अलविदा (*alvidā*) — “the farewell”

The letters in this word

New: the independent vowel अ (“a,” for a word that *starts* with a vowel) and ल la. अ·ल·वि·दा → *alvidā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अलविदा came through Persian from **Arabic** *al-widā'* (“the farewell”), root **w-d-'**. At the front is अल — the Arabic article *al-*, “the,” the same one riding inside English *algebra* and *alcohol*. So *alvidā* is literally “the farewell.”

Why it's said this way

Carries **finality** — the goodbye for a long or final parting. For casual “bye,” Hindi uses *namaste* again, or *phir milenge* (“we’ll meet again”). Next chapter: *āp* vs. *tum* (formal and informal “you”), and introducing yourself.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

मेरा नाम मीरा है। (merā nām Mira hai — “My name is Mira.”)
आपका नाम क्या है? (āpkā nām kyā hai — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C02-*.md.*

2.1 नाम (nām) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

Three letters, left to right: न (na), ा the long-ā mātrā (ना = nā), म (ma).
Read ना·म → nām.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाम (nām) ← Sanskrit नामन् (nāman), from Proto-Indo-European *h₃nómn. — the same ancient root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**, **nominate**), and Greek *onoma*. So Hindi *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed — one of the clearest bridges between the Indian and European branches of the same family.

2.2 मेरा (*merā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

म (*ma*) + े (the *e-mātrā*) → मे (*me*); then र (*ra*) + ा (long *ā*) → रा (*rā*).
Read मे-रा → *merā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मेरा (*merā*, “my”) descends from Sanskrit *mad-īya* (“of me”), on the first-person root *ma-* — the same *ma-/me-* behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *meus*. The Hindi “my” and the English “my” are, at the root, the same word.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees with the noun. Hindi possessives change to match what is owned: *merā* (masculine), *merī* (feminine), *mere* (plural). *nām* is masculine, so it takes *merā*: *merā nām*. (You will meet *merī* the first time you own a feminine noun.)

2.3 है (*hai*) — “is,” cousin of English *is*

The letters in this word

ह (*ha*) + ै (the *ai-mātrā*) → है (*hai*). One syllable.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

है (*hai*, “is”) ← Sanskrit अस्ति (*asti*, “is”), from Proto-Indo-European **h₁es-* — the root of “to be” across the whole family: English *is*, German *ist*, Latin *est*, Spanish *es*, French *est*. Hindi *hai* is the Indian cousin of the same little verb — “is” really is one word from Ireland to India.

2.4 मेरा नाम ...है (*merā nām ...hai*) — “my name is...”

मेरा (*my*) + नाम (*name*) + है (*is*) = *merā nām ...hai*, “my name is...” *Merā nām Arun hai.* = “My name is Arun.”

2.5. आप / तुम (Āp / TUM) — “YOU,” RESPECTFUL AND FAMILIAR⁹

Grammar Lens

Word order: the verb goes last. Hindi is a *subject-object-verb* language — literally “my name Arun *is*.” The *hai* sits at the end, where English puts “is” in the middle. Bank this shape: in Hindi, the verb waits until the end of the sentence.

2.5 आप / तुम (*āp* / *tum*) — “you,” respectful and familiar

The letters in this word

आप: the independent vowel आ (*ā*, word-initial) + प (*pa*) → *āp*. तुम: त (*ta*) + उ (the *u*-sign) + म (*ma*) → *tum*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

तुम (*tum*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE *tū — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*. आप (*āp*, respectful “you”) is a different, honorific word (originally “oneself”).

Grammar Lens

Three levels of “you.” Hindi grades respect in three: *āp* (respectful — strangers, elders, politeness), *tum* (familiar — friends, peers), *tū* (intimate or to a child, and can insult if misused). Each of the earlier tracks had two levels; Hindi has three. For a first meeting, always *āp*.

2.6 क्या (*kyā*) — “what”

The letters in this word

A **conjunct**: क (*ka*) loses its vowel (*halant*) and joins य (*ya*) → क्य (*kya*); add the long-*ā* mātrā → क्या (*kyā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

क्या (*kyā*, “what”) ← Sanskrit *kim* / the interrogative stem *ka-*, from PIE *k^wo- — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words (**what**, **who**, **which**) and Latin *qu-*. Hindi’s question-words nearly all start

with this *k-*: *kyā* (what), *kaun* (who), *kab* (when), *kyūn* (why) — the Indian branch of the same family of question-words.

2.7 आपका नाम क्या है? (*āpkā nām kyā hai*) — “what’s your name?”

आपका (*āpkā*, “your”) = आप (you) + का (*kā*, the possessive “of,” the same agreeing *kā/kī/ke* that matches the noun). So आपका नाम क्या है? is literally “**your name what is?**” — Hindi keeps the verb last again, and simply drops the question-word *kyā* into the object slot.

Grammar Lens

Answer it with the sentence you built: *Merā nām Arun hai*. The informal version swaps *āpkā* for *tumhārā*: *tumhārā nām kyā hai?*

2.8 खुशी (*khushī*) — “happiness,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The Hindi “pleased to meet you” is आपसे मिलकर खुशी हुई (*āp-se milkar khushī huī*) — literally “**having met you, happiness happened.**” The key word खुशी (*khushī*, “happiness”) is **not** Sanskrit — it is **Persian** (*khush*, “happy, pleasant”), one of the thousands of Persian words in everyday Hindi. So even introducing yourself draws on Hindi’s *two* vocabularies: Sanskrit (*nām*, *hai*) and Perso-Arabic (*khushī*).

2.9 The whole exchange

Hindi	English
मेरा नाम मीरा है।	My name is Mira.
आपका नाम क्या है?	What’s your name?
मेरा नाम अरुण है।	My name is Arun.
आपसे मिलकर खुशी हुई।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nām* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *merā* (root *ma-*, English *my*), *hai* (Sanskrit *asti*, English *is*), *kyā* (root *ka-*, English *what*). And two Hindi habits: the **verb goes last**, and “you” has **three** respect-levels. Next chapter: *āp kaise hai?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *thik* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — asking, and answering, how someone is:

आप कैसे हैं? (*āp kaise haiṃ* — “How are you?”)
मैं ठीक हूँ, धन्यवाद। (*maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ, dhanyavād* — “I’m fine, thank you.”)

Every atom traced, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C03-*.md.*

3.1 कैसे (*kaise*) — “how,” another of the k- questions

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + ै (the *ai*-mātrā) → कै (*kai*); स (*sa*) + े (the *e*-mātrā) → से (*se*). Read कै-से → *kaise*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कैसे (*kaise*, “how”) ← Sanskrit *kīdrśa* (“of what kind”) / the interrogative stem *ka-*, from Proto-Indo-European **k^wo-* — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words and Latin *qu-*. Hindi’s questions nearly all begin with this *k-*: *kyā* (what), *kaun* (who), *kab* (when), *kahāṃ* (where), *kaise* (how).

Grammar Lens

The adjective कैसा (*kaisā*) agrees: *kaisā* (m.), *kaisī* (f.), *kaise* (m. plural / respectful). Because the respectful “you” (*āp*) takes a plural verb, “how are you?” uses the plural कैसे.

3.2 आप कैसे हैं? (*āp kaise haiṃ*) — “how are you?”

हैं is है (*hai*, “is”) + the *anusvāra* ँ → हैं (*haiṃ*), the nasalised plural. So आप कैसे हैं? is literally “**you how are?**” — verb last, and because *āp* is grammatically plural (that is how Hindi shows respect), its verb is the plural *haiṃ*, not *hai*.

Grammar Lens

Respect is plural. To an elder or stranger: *āp kaise haiṃ?* To a friend: *tum kaise ho?* (*ho* is the familiar “are”). Match the “you” to the verb: *āp ... haiṃ*, *tum ... ho*.

3.3 मैं (*maiṃ*) — “I,” the m- of the first person

The letters in this word

म (*ma*) + ञ् (*ai*) + the *anusvāra* ँ → मैं (*maiṃ*). One nasal syllable.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मैं (*maiṃ*, “I”) ← Sanskrit *mayā* (“by me”), on the first-person root *ma-* — the same root behind Chapter 2’s *merā* (“my”) and behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *mē*. Hindi’s “I,” its “my,” and English’s “me/my” grow from one ancient first-person sound.

3.4 हूँ (*hūṃ*) — “am,” cousin of English *am*

The letters in this word

ह (*ha*) + ू (long *u*) → हू (*hū*); the *chandrabindu* ँ nasalises → हूँ (*hūṃ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

हूँ (*hūṃ*, “am”) ← Sanskrit *asmi* (“I am”) — the first person of the root that also gave you *hai*. That root, PIE **h₁es-*, is “to be” across the family: *asmi* → English **am**, Latin *sum*; *asti* → *hai* / English *is*. The copula lines up person by person: हूँ *am*, है *is*, हैं *are*.

3.5 ठीक (*ṭhīk*) — “fine,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ठ (*ṭha*, a **retroflex** *th* — tongue curled to the roof of the mouth) + ी (long *ī*) + क (*ka*) → ठीक. The retroflex ट-ठ-ड series is a hallmark of Indian sound.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ठीक (*ṭhīk*) means “correct, right, fine, exactly, OK.” It is a genuinely **native** Indian word — no European cousin — and one of the most useful in the language. Not every word has a far-flung cognate, and that is worth seeing too: *ṭhīk* is Indian to the core.

Put the atoms together: मैं ठीक हूँ (*maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ*) — “I am fine” (literally “I fine am”). The whole exchange:

— āp kaise haiṃ? — maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ, dhanyavād.

3.6 आपका स्वागत है (*āpkā svāgat hai*) — “you’re welcome”

The letters in this word

The key word स्वागत (*svāgat*): the conjunct स्व (स् *s* + व *va* → *sva*) + ग (*ga*) + त (*ta*), with आपका (*āpkā*, “your”) and है (*hai*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आपका स्वागत है = “your welcome is” → “**you are welcome.**” The heart, स्वागत (*svāgat*), is Sanskrit *su* (“well, good”) + *āgata* (“come”) — “**well come,**” exactly like English *welcome*. Inside it: *su-* the twin of Greek *eu-* (*euphoria*), and *āgata* from the root *gam* (“go/come”), cousin of English *come*. You will meet *svāgatam* again, unchanged, in the Sanskrit track.

3.7 The whole exchange

Hindi	English
आप कैसे हैं?	How are you?
मैं ठीक हूँ, धन्यवाद।	I'm fine, thank you.
आपका स्वागत है।	You're welcome.

Every atom traced: *kaise* (the interrogative *k-*, English *how*), *maiṃ* (root *ma-*, English *me*), *hūṃ* (Sanskrit *asmi*, English *am*), *svāgat* (*su* + *āgata* = “well come”). You now hold the copula trio — *hūṃ* / *hai* / *haiṃ*. Next chapter: the farewells, from the formal *alvidā* to the warm *phir milenge*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the grave, formal अलविदा (*alvidā*). Real days end more warmly — with a promise to meet again:

फिर मिलेंगे! (*phir milenge* — “We’ll meet again!”)

Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C04-.md.*

4.1 फिर (*phir*) — “again”

The letters in this word

फ (*pha*, an aspirated *p*) + ि (the *i*-mātrā, written before but read after) + र (*ra*) → फिर.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

फिर (*phir*) means “again, then, afterwards” — a native Indo-Aryan adverb with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar *job*: it turns a parting into a promise. English “see you *again*”; Hindi *phir milenge*.

4.2 मिलेंगे (*milenge*) — “(we) will meet”

The letters in this word

मि (*mi*) + ले (*le*) + the *anusvāra* + गे (*ge*) → मिलेंगे (*milenge*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मिलेंगे (*milenge*, “we will meet”) is the future of मिलना (*milnā*, “to meet, to be found”), from Sanskrit *mil-* (“to join, unite”) — the root of *milan* (“a meeting, union”). The ending -एंगे (*-enge*) is the plural future.

Grammar Lens

The future is an ending, not a helper. *mil-* (“meet”) + *-enge* (“we/they will”) → *milenge*. No word like English “will” — the tense lives in the ending, as person lives in *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ*.

4.3 फिर मिलेंगे (*phir milenge*) — “we’ll meet again”

फिर (again) + मिलेंगे (we will meet) = “**we’ll meet again.**” Where अलविदा (*alvidā*) is grave and final — and, fittingly, a **Perso-Arabic** word (*al-widā*, “the farewell”) — *phir milenge* is native, everyday, and hopeful, the sibling of the “promise of return” goodbyes across South Asia (Tamil, Bengali, Marathi all say “I’ll come again”).

Grammar Lens

Two registers: अलविदा (formal, final, Perso-Arabic) versus फिर मिलेंगे (everyday, warm, native). Even more casual: *phir milte haiṃ* (“(we) meet again,” present for a near future).

4.4 कल मिलते हैं (*kal milte haiṃ*) — “see you tomorrow”**The letters in this word**

क (*ka*) + ल (*la*) → कल (*kal*). Two simple letters, one tricky word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कल (*kal*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit *kāla* (“time”), the very root behind Punjabi’s *akāl* (“timeless”). Context and the verb’s tense tell which: *kal milte haiṃ* (“tomorrow”), *kal milā* (“yesterday”).

Grammar Lens

मिलते हैं (*milte haiṃ*) is literally “(we) meet” — Hindi, like English (“I’m seeing you tomorrow”), uses the present for a scheduled future.

4.5 चलता हूँ (*caltā hūṃ*) — “I’ll be off”**The letters in this word**

च (*ca*) + ल (*la*) + long *ā* → चलता (*caltā*), with हूँ (*hūṃ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

चलता हूँ literally “**I go / I move**” — used like English “I’ll be off.” The verb चलना (*calnā*, “to move, walk, go”) is from Sanskrit *cal-* (“to move, stir”) — the root of *calan* (“circulation”) and *cañcal* (“restless”). Like Bengali *āshi* and Marathi *yeto*, Hindi leaves by saying “I’m *moving*,” never a blunt “I’m leaving.”

Grammar Lens

The verb agrees with the speaker’s gender. A man says चलता हूँ (*caltā hūṃ*); a woman says चलती हूँ (*caltī hūṃ*). The *-tā* / *-tī* ending marks the speaker — a feature English lacks (compare Marathi *yeto* m. / *yete* f.).

4.6 The farewells

Hindi		Register
अलविदा	<i>alvidā</i>	formal, final (Perso-Arabic)
फिर मिलेंगे	<i>phir milenge</i>	everyday, “we’ll meet again”
कल मिलते हैं	<i>kal milte haiṃ</i>	“see you tomorrow”
चलता हूँ	<i>caltā/caltī hūṃ</i>	casual, “I’ll be off”

Roots banked: *milenge* (*mil-* “to join”), *kal* (*kāla* “time,” cousin of Punjabi *akāl*), *caltā* (*cal-* “to move,” the *-tā*/*-tī* marking the speaker’s gender). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ* — and Hindi’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ। (*maiṁ hindī boltā hūṁ* — “I speak Hindi.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/HI-C05-.md.*

5.1 बोलना (*bolnā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ब (*ba*) + ो (the *o-mātrā*) → बो (*bo*); ल (*la*); ना (*nā*). Read बो·ल·ना → *bolnā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बोलना (*bolnā*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (Prakrit *bolla-*, “to utter”). Its ending -ना (*-nā*) is the point: **every** Hindi infinitive ends in *-nā* — *bol-nā* “to speak,” *cal-nā* “to move,” *mil-nā* “to meet.” Strip the *-nā* and you have the **stem** (*bol-*) that takes every other ending.

Grammar Lens

Stem + ending. The stem *bol-* holds the action; endings pin down who and when: *bol-tā* (speaking, m.), *bol-tī* (f.), *bol-o* (speak!, familiar). Every tense is built by adding to a stem like this.

5.2 मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ (*maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ*) — “I speak Hindi”

मैं (I) + हिंदी (Hindi, the object) + बोलता (speak, m.) + हूँ (am) = literally “I Hindi speaking am” — verb-frame last, as always.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The name हिंदी (*hindī*) is a traveller: from *sindhu* (the river Indus) → Persian *hind* (the land beyond it) → *hindī* (“of Hind”). The same *sindhu* gave Greek *Indos* → English **India**, **Indus**, **Hindu**. The language is named, at two removes, after a river.

Grammar Lens

The present habitual = stem + *-tā/-tī* + “to be.”

	Hindi	
a man	मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ	<i>boltā hūṃ</i>
a woman	मैं हिंदी बोलती हूँ	<i>boltī hūṃ</i>
you (resp.)	आप हिंदी बोलते हैं	<i>bolte haiṃ</i>

The *-tā/-tī/-te* agrees in gender and number; *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ* agrees in person. Two agreements, one small sentence.

5.3 रहना (*rahnā*) — “to live, to stay”

The letters in this word

र (*ra*) + ह (*ha*) + ना (*nā*) → रहना. The familiar infinitive -ना.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

रहना (*rahnā*, “to live, remain, stay”), from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain”), covers both “reside” and “keep on”: *maiṃ Dillī meṃ rahtā hūṃ* (“I live in Delhi”), *thīk rahnā* (“stay well”).

5.4. करना (KARNĀ) — “TO DO,” THE MOST USEFUL VERB IN HINDI 23

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. मैं दिल्ली में रहता हूँ — the word मैं (*meṃ*, “in”) sits *after* Delhi. Hindi uses **postpositions** where English uses prepositions: “Delhi-in I live,” verb last.

5.4 करना (*karnā*) — “to do,” the most useful verb in Hindi

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + र (*ra*) + ना (*nā*) → करना.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करना (*karnā*, “to do, make”) is from the Sanskrit root *kr* (“to do, make”), PIE *k^wer- — one of the most productive roots in Sanskrit. Its family is already all around you: *karma* (“a thing *done*”), *namaskār* (“the *making* of a bow,” Chapter 1), and the name *Sanskrit* itself (*saṃskṛta*, “put together, perfected”).

Grammar Lens

करना makes verbs out of anything. Noun + *karnā*: *kām karnā* (“work-do” = to work), *bāt karnā* (“talk-do” = to converse), *intizār karnā* (“to wait”). So *maiṃ kām kartā hūṃ* = “I work.”

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Hindi	English
मैं हिंदी बोलता/बोलती हूँ।	I speak Hindi.
मैं दिल्ली में रहता/रहती हूँ।	I live in Delhi.
मैं काम करता/करती हूँ।	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, the *-tā/-tī/-te* that agrees in gender/number, and the *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ* that agrees in person — the verb always last, “in” always after its noun. Roots banked: *bolnā* (Prakrit *bolla-*), *rahnā* (*rah-* “remain”), *karnā* (*kr* — the root of *karma*, *namaskār*, *Sanskrit*), and *hindī* (*sindhu*, the Indus). From here, Hindi’s sentences only grow.